# Auditory Processing

A POND GUIDE — CONTESTED GROUND

**Your hearing test comes back perfect, and yet you still can't follow a conversation in a pub. Both of those things can be true. Whether this belongs under the neurodivergent umbrella is genuinely debated. Many people who have it identify as neurodivergent; some prefer not to. Both are reasonable, and nobody gets to decide it for you.**

## In plain words

Auditory Processing Disorder affects how the brain interprets sound rather than how the ear detects it. Hearing is typically normal. What's difficult is separating speech from background noise, processing fast speech, and holding spoken instructions long enough to act on them. It commonly travels with ADHD, autism and dyslexia.

## What it can feel like from the inside

- Hearing every word and assembling the meaning several seconds late.
- A busy café turning speech into an unsortable wall of sound.
- Saying 'what?' then answering before they repeat it.
- Mishearing similar-sounding words constantly.
- Being exhausted by a day of listening, because it's active work.

## What people often get wrong

| THE ASSUMPTION | WHAT'S ACTUALLY GOING ON |
|---|---|
| "Get your ears tested." | Already done. They're fine. That's rather the point. |
| "You weren't listening." | Listening was happening at maximum effort the whole time. |
| "I'll just say it louder." | Volume isn't the problem. Clarity, pace and background noise are. |
| "You heard me before." | Quiet room versus noisy room is an enormous difference here. |
| "They're away with the fairies." | They're two sentences behind, catching up. |

## What often comes with it

NOT COMPENSATION PRIZES — GENUINE, USEFUL THINGS

Excellent visual and written comprehension.

Strong pattern-spotting in text.

Genuine empathy for anyone struggling to follow.

Highly developed strategies for checking and confirming.

Often unusually good at reading faces and body language.

## What actually helps

- ☐ Get their attention before speaking
- ☐ Slower and clearer beats louder
- ☐ Choose quiet places to talk
- ☐ Face them, don't call from another room
- ☐ Back it up in writing
- ☐ Don't mind repeating

## If someone tells you this is them

**HELPFUL**

“Shall I text you that?”

“Let's sit somewhere quieter.”

“No problem, I'll say it again.”

**LESS HELPFUL**

“ARE YOU DEAF?”

“I've told you three times.”

“You only hear what you want to.”

*The ears are fine. It's the sorting office that's under pressure.*

A friendly explainer written for the community — not a diagnostic tool and not medical advice. If you want an assessment, your GP is the place to start. Nobody experiences this identically, so take what fits and leave the rest.

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